



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing at Hyderabad House in New Delhi, Monday. ANIL SHARMA

Won't allow our territory to be used against India's interests: Myanmar

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 1

MYANMAR PRESIDENT U Min Aung Hlaing assured Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday that Myanmar's territory "would not be permitted to be used against India's security interests".

In the past, India has repeatedly expressed concern

over Northeast insurgent groups operating from within Myanmar.

Briefing reporters after the bilateral meeting, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri underlined that "stability and peace in Myanmar is a major interest for India".

Min Aung Hlaing is visiting India from May 30 to June 3 — his first visit since taking over

as President. The former chief of the military junta government was elected President on April 3, five years after he grabbed power in a coup, ousting an elected government.

Misri said the leaders discussed cooperation on defence and security, critical minerals and rare earth, and connectivity projects.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FOUR-DAY TRADE TALKS

India seeks edge over Asian peers in US talks

10% tariffs lapse in July, Trump can use Section 301 to levy higher duties

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 1

AS NEGOTIATORS from India and the US begin what seems like the final round of talks before formally signing a bilateral trade agreement, Commerce and Industry Ministry officials Monday said New Delhi is seeking an edge over Asian competitors under the new set of Section 301 tariffs Washington is expected to announce before July-end.

The US had earlier said it would use Section 301, which gives it powers to slap higher import duty on countries hurting its industry, after the President Donald Trump administration lost the case on reciprocal tariffs in the US Supreme Court. Immediately after this loss, the US had imposed 10% global tariffs under Section 122. This lapses on July 24, which creates the urgency for New Delhi to sign a trade deal within the next 5-7 weeks.

The framework for the US-

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



India bilateral trade agreement was agreed upon in February when the US said it would bring down tariffs to 18% from an effective tariff of 50% (25% reciprocal and 25% penalty for buying Russian oil).

"Now the fight is about Section 301, which is the only statute available to the administration given by the US Congress. The rates do not matter in this case; preferential market access

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Telangana bans salary in cash, brings gig workers under minimum wage net

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 1

A BAN on cash wage payments, mandatory electronic transfer and bringing gig workers under the country's minimum wages law — that's what the Telangana government has done through a government order that was issued recently.

This comes months after the Telangana Assembly passed The Telangana Platform-Based

Gig Workers (Registration, Social Security and Welfare) Act, 2026. The GO serves as the mechanism to execute that law by bringing eCommerce, courier, and platform workers under the official minimum wage net and tightening wage payment compliance.

Issued on May 30, but coming into force Monday, the order — GO Ms No. 6 — activates the provisions of the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Wage security

The government order brings e-commerce, courier and platform workers under official minimum wage net and tightens wage-payment compliance. Platforms are now required to pay overtime at double the standard rate.

• CULTURE MINISTRY, NGMA, GUJRAL FOUNDATION WORKING ON PLAN TO REMOVE, RELOCATE MURALS INSTALLED IN 1968

Shastri Bhawan to be razed, Satish Gujral murals to find new home

Damini Nath
New Delhi, June 1

ALMOST 60 YEARS after they were installed, murals by artist Satish Gujral on the facade of Shastri Bhawan are set to be removed and relocated before the building's demolition for the Central Vista redevelopment project, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

As part of the government's redevelopment project, Shastri Bhawan and the adjoining Krishi Bhawan are set to be demolished soon to pave the way for two new office buildings — Common Central Secretariat (Kartavya Bhawan) 4 and 5. The Central Public Works Depart-

ment (CPWD) has floated the tender for the project, which includes the demolition of the existing structures. The last date for bids is June 6, with an estimated cost of Rs 3,218.44 crore, as per the tender document.

According to government officials, the Ministry of Culture, National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) and Gujral Foundation are currently working on a plan to move the ceramic tile murals, spanning the height of the seven-storey building, which were installed on the facade of Shastri Bhawan in 1968. The final place for the murals has not been decided yet, they said.

When reached for comment, Mohit Gujral, son of Satish Gujral and the co-founder of the Gujral Foundation, said: "The National Gallery of Modern Art has been consulting conservation experts to determine the most appropriate methodology for undertaking this complex exercise and has remained in touch with the Gujral Foundation wherever necessary during the process."

Kishore Singh, an independent art consultant and the curator of the Satish Gujral retrospective at NGMA earlier this year marking the artist's centennial, said the Shastri Bha-

wan murals were among several installed by the artist in the 1960s.

"Satish Gujral had gone to study mural-making in Mexico in the 1950s from Diego Rivera and David Alfaro Siqueiros. He was the first Indian artist to go on a scholarship to study mural-making. When he came back, he started making his murals using ceramic tiles. He made murals for the Delhi High Court, Baroda House and Shastri Bhawan. If his murals are being removed and relocated, it is a progressive step and sets a good precedent," Singh said.

With the work on the build-

ings likely to start soon, the murals are expected to be removed within a month.

Under the government's Central Vista plan, 10 new Common Central Secretariat (CCS) buildings have been proposed to house all Union Ministries. The new buildings are to come up at the site of existing offices and other government buildings. Last month, Nirman Bhawan became the first of the old office buildings to be demolished. The demolition of Udyog Bhawan, Shastri Bhawan and Krishi Bhawan are expected to start soon.

Started in 2019, the Central Vista plan includes the construction of the new Parliament

building, Vice-President's Enclave and Executive Enclave (Prime Minister's Office, Cabinet Secretariat and the National Security Council Secretariat). Of the 10 CCS buildings, three have been completed, while tendering or construction of the remaining seven are underway. The construction of the Prime Minister's residence is also underway.

As of February this year, according to a reply by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs in Parliament, the total sanctioned cost of the projects, including Parliament, Vice-President's Enclave and Kartavya Bhawan, was Rs 13,169.61 crore.



The mural by Satish Gujral at Shastri Bhawan. GUJRAL FOUNDATION

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India seeks edge over Asian peers in US talks

is what matters,” a Commerce and Industry Ministry official said.

“We are not willing to lower duties unless our goods get preferential market access in the US compared with our competitors in Southeast Asian countries. The duty imposed by the US on the European Union or other developed countries does not affect us because our goods are not competing with them,” the official said.

At a media conference on Monday to announce the operationalisation of the FTA with Oman, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said the negotiations are more or less complete and that India and the US have already agreed upon the first tranche of the framework agreement. “Talks will continue for a broader bilateral trade agreement,” he said, adding he expected to meet USTR Jamieson Greer later this month.

However, experts pointed out that Section 301 tariffs could be worse than IEEPA (International Emergency Economic Powers Act) tariffs that the Trump administration used to pressurise trade partners into accepting steep demands under

trade deals. India was on the receiving end of the steepest 50% tariffs last year after trade talks broke down in the face of demands made by the US that were perceived as unreasonable by New Delhi.

Section 301 tariffs are stricter than IEEPA

After the Trump administration lost the authority to impose tariffs under IEEPA in February following a legal challenge, the administration in Washington DC opened a new Section 301 investigation within a month over excess manufacturing capacity against 16 countries, including India, China, the European Union, Singapore, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, and Bangladesh, among others. Just a day after, the USTR initiated a second investigation on forced labour, probing 60 countries, including India.

According to Singapore based-Hinrich Foundation, Section 301 is far more potent than the overturned use of the IEEPA because it comes with greater legal certainty for the executive branch.

“Under the rules, USTR is

authorised to impose duties or other import restrictions, withdraw or suspend trade agreement concessions, enter into binding agreements with the foreign government to eliminate the conduct or unburden US commerce, or compensate the US with satisfactory trade benefits. Because Section 301 need not apply only to goods, other retaliatory actions are allowed, such as restricting the terms or conditions or denying the issuance of any ‘service sector access authorisation,’” the Foundation said.

While Section 301 cases are meant to terminate automatically in four years, this period can be extended or reinstated by USTR without Congressional oversight, the Foundation said, adding that under Section 301, “the US effectively acts as judge, jury, and executioner”.

India is worst hit by tariffs

India was one of the worst hit by tariffs that resulted in a flight of foreign investment and resulted in steep depreciation of the domestic currency. The rupee has fallen almost 12% in the last one year. A formal trade

deal remained aloof for months as the US demanded that India wind down imports of Russian oil and accept genetically-modified American agricultural products.

The India-US joint statement of February said India will eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including dried distillers’ grains (DDGs), red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products.

Indicating signs of disagreement, the US later revised a factsheet softening its claims about the gains it had secured from New Delhi and entirely dropping a section on digital services taxes. The earlier version of the factsheet said India had “committed to” buying more American products and purchasing “over \$500 billion of U.S. energy, information and communication technology, coal, and other products”. The updated factsheet, as well as the joint statement, tempered the wording from “committed” to “intends”.

Myanmar

Modi also raised the issue of Nobel laureate Aung San Suu Kyi, who is in detention in Myanmar since the military coup in 2021.

“The Prime Minister reaffirmed India’s support for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Republic of the Union of Myanmar, and both sides underscored the importance of preventing the misuse of sovereign territory for activities inimical to their security interests. The President of Myanmar, in particular, reiterated the assurance that Myanmar’s territory would not be permitted to be used against India’s security interests,” Misri said.

“The aspect of internal security is obviously the effort by the Myanmar State to bring all the ethnic armed organisations and groups onto a single platform to advance the peace process... this is something in which we obviously have an interest, because stability and peace in Myanmar is a major interest for India, not just for the security of the Northeast and the safety and security of people living along the 1,643-km-long border that we have with them, but also for our interests, such as connectivity to Southeast Asia,” Misri said.

“Security and stability in Myanmar is also important for

the coherence of ASEAN as a whole, because Myanmar is an important and large country within the ASEAN framework,” he said, outlining the regional dimension.

“Apart from that, there is the very important question of the activities of Indian insurgent groups in Myanmar close to our borders, and this is something that the Prime Minister raised with the President. The President once again reiterated his assurance that Myanmar was sensitive to these concerns, and would do everything necessary to ensure that there was action on these, and these don’t become a cause of threat against the security of India,” he said.

Responding to questions on Suu Kyi, Misri said: “The Prime Minister did raise this matter with the President, and this was a discussion that was largely in the context of the peace process... in the context of the points that the Prime Minister was making on the need for... inclusion, the need to have all stakeholders at the table and to examine the points of views of all the interlocutors who have been part of this process... it was a bit of a freewheeling discussion on that issue, and that is where issues related to democracy were also raised.”

Underlining that the engagement with Myanmar is “not intended to be a commentary on its internal political arrange-

ments”, Misri said: “We have always proceeded on the principle that sustained dialogue is what is important and... an imperative for India as a neighbour... the answer is clearly not disengagement... So we have consistently engaged, and while engaging, we have always put forward our thoughts on all of these issues related to democracy, the peace process, inclusion, and the absolute importance of having all stakeholders as part of the dialogue at the table.”

“We have always believed that eventually the difficulties that face Myanmar will have to be sorted out by the people of Myanmar talking among themselves. This will have to be a Myanmar-led solution and a Myanmar-owned solution,” he said.

On defence cooperation, Misri said the focus is on “training”, “capacity building”, institution building, and UN peace-keeping. “...we have a 1,643-km-long border. There are important defence and security related interests in the context of that border, and that is also something that gets discussed when various mechanisms related to defence cooperation get together,” he said.

Misri also said that over the last year-and-a-half, over 2,400 Indian citizens have been repatriated from cyber scam compounds within Myanmar. “As of now, we have over 150-odd In-

dian citizens that we know of... who are still stuck in some of these cyber scam compounds... we are in touch with the Myanmar government to try and repatriate them as well,” he said.

On the two major connectivity-related projects — the Kaladan multimodal transit transport project and India-Myanmar-Thailand trilateral highway project — Misri said: “These projects have been underway for several years, and they have been delayed... Right now, the obstacle that faces both these projects is the security situation in Myanmar. The Kaladan highway is in an area where there are active hostilities going on between the Myanmar Army and ethnic armies in Rakhine state; the section of the trilateral highway where work was underway is in an area where ethnic armed groups are quite active... Nevertheless, we have continued to engage with the Myanmar authorities, and wherever there has been a possibility to take forward the work by utilising either hulls in fighting or by making sure that the security of the workers is not going to be impacted, we have been able to move forward, but this is something that that remains a major priority. It was raised by the PM today, and the President once again gave his assurance Myanmar would do everything to ensure these projects move forward towards completion.”

Telangana bans salary in cash

Centre’s Code on Wages, 2019, completely repealing and superseding the Minimum Wages Act, 1948, across the state, a statement from the government explaining the provisions of the GO read.

“Payouts via paper cash are explicitly banned. Employers must disburse wages through direct electronic transfer (NEFT/RTGS/IMPS) or bank cheque, building an unalterable trail for labour inspectors and protecting vulnerable workgroups,” it said.

The GO also brings into effect “paid weekly rest days (Sundays off) into the basic monthly compensation matrix, ensuring workers do not lose income for resting,” the statement read. “Any task executed past standard 8-hour daily shifts, or requested on public holidays and weekly rest days, must be compensated as overtime at double (two times) the standard rate of wages”.

Telangana has formalised gig and platform protection by explicitly extending the minimum wage net to eCommerce, courier Services, and LPG distribution, the statement read. The GO formally recognises specialised designations such as Drone Technology Pesticide Sprayers under the ‘Highly Skilled’ category, securing premium wages for future professions.

To cut corporate red tape and ensure direct compliance clarity, the order eliminates hundreds of industry-specific schedules. The order categorises all non-agricultural, commercial, and industrial setups into four skill categories and workers are divided into four categories — unskilled,

semi-skilled, skilled and highly skilled — for fixing minimum wages. The state has been divided into three zones — Zone 1 covers Municipal Corporations, Zone 2 — Municipalities and Zone 3 — Rural Areas.

In Zone 1, the minimum wage for unskilled workers has increased from Rs 12,750 to Rs 16,000; for semi-skilled workers, from Rs 13,152 to Rs 17,000; for the skilled category, from Rs 13,772 to Rs 18,500; and for the highly skilled category, from Rs 14,607 to Rs 20,000.

“The clear distinction between Municipal Corporations (Zone-I), Municipalities (Zone-II), and Rural Areas (Zone-III) lets large-scale industrial developers set up labour-intensive projects in sectors such as textiles and manufacturing in lower-overhead rural zones while managing corporate setups in urban centres,” the statement read.

According to the statement, “the order established absolute gender neutrality, mandating perfectly uniform minimum wage rates for male, female, transgender, and physically challenged employees performing identical or equivalent work”.

To eliminate the legal loopholes of subcontracting, the order stated that “if a third-party agency fails to deliver wages, the principal employer is directly liable under law to ensure immediate payroll settlement”.

The GO creates “an ideal macroeconomic harmony, proving that robust labour protections and a booming, highly competitive business climate can thrive together”, the statement read.

● Rs 5 LAKH CRORE INVESTMENT IN FOCUS

‘Make in Haryana’ policy eyes future-ready industries with AI-driven ecosystem

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 1

A DEDICATED push for data centres and global capability centres (GCCs), which aim to leverage talent polls, an Artificial Intelligence-driven facilitation ecosystem that will automate investment blueprint generation and mega private industrial parks to house future-ready industries: these are among the highlights of ‘Make in Haryana’ Industrial Policy launched by Chief Minister

Nayab Singh Saini on Monday. Aiming to draw Rs 5 lakh crore in investments, the policy aims to position Haryana as a powerhouse for future-ready manufacturing and emerging technologies, said officials.

Eyeing a transition from traditional manufacturing to innovation-led industrial growth, the CM unveiled the framework alongside nine new sector-specific policies in Gurgaon, officials underlined. “Investors now evaluate the overall ecosystem. They ask which state can make

faster decisions, which state can provide trust and reliability, and which state can emerge as a long-term growth partner,” Saini said, calling “speed and trust” the government’s guiding principles.

A central pillar of the newly-launched policy framework is its focus on next-generation technology, officials said. Among the nine sectoral policies introduced, the government has carved out dedicated strategies for data centres, electronics, emerging industries,

● FINANCIAL INCENTIVES TO WOO INVESTORS



CAPITAL AND TAX SUPPORT: Up to 30% capital subsidy, along with net state GST

reimbursement to improve project viability.

INNOVATION BOOST: Research and Development (R&D) incentives of up to Rs 50 crore to promote innovation-led manufacturing and integration with global value chains.



CENTRAL SCHEME TOP-UPS: A 50% top-up on incentives received under

Centre’s schemes, such as the Production Linked Incentive (PLI).

SUSTAINABILITY SUBSIDIES: Fiscal support for green manufacturing, including renewable energy adoption, zero liquid discharge systems, and carbon credit generation.



EXPORT RELIEF: Special one-time diversification support for export-oriented

units affected by geopolitical disruptions.

SPEED AND TRUST: Addressing industry leaders, and foreign delegations, the CM emphasised that ease of doing business is no longer enough and insisted on the need of speed and trust.

and advanced manufacturing. New investments in “non-ToD” areas of Gurgaon, referring to non-transit oriented development zones, are in focus in the GCC & the Data Center Policies 2026 for the sectors related to emerging technologies, officials underlined. Demonstrating immediate industry backing, the state signed MoUs worth Rs 1.10 lakh crore on the very first day, which includes Rs 30,000 crore in Foreign Direct Investment (FDI).

From basic digitisation, the

state has transitioned to “intelligent governance”, the CM said. A revamped “Single Window 2.0” system — the Intelligent Investment Facilitation Portal — has been launched, which uses a “Smart AI Agent” for conversational, real-time troubleshooting, as per the policy.

The portal features an AI-enabled Investment Blueprint generator, allowing investors to calculate potential incentives and regulatory requirements, alongside a geographic information system based platform.



NFHS-5 FACTSHEET HAD 131 KEY INDICATORS; NFHS-6 HAS 101

Missing from NFHS: Key indicators linked to sex ratio, cancer screening

Nikhila Henry & Anonna Dutt
Hyderabad, New Delhi, June 1

SEVERAL DATA points from the fifth National Family Health Survey (NFHS) have been omitted from the NFHS-6 factsheet released on May 29, despite questions corresponding to these having been asked during the survey conducted between 2023 and 2024.

The omitted data points include several population-level statistics, indicators related to women's and children's health, family planning, and data on central government schemes such as the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan (sanitation) and the Ujjwala Yojana (cooking fuel).

Sources in the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare explained that several data points in the NFHS were being reported by other surveys, and the omissions were an attempt at "data harmonisation".

The NFHS is a large-scale household survey conducted across India to track vital data on health, family welfare, and nutrition. Indicators help policymakers evaluate and design effective public health programmes. The first such survey took place in 1992-93. It is conducted by the International Institute of Population Sciences (IIPS), under the supervision of the Ministry of Health and

Health Ministry rationale: Several data points in NFHS reported by other surveys, omissions an attempt at "data harmonisation"

Family Welfare.

The NFHS-5 (2019-21) factsheet had 131 key indicators or data points at the national level, while the NFHS-6 factsheet has 101.

Omissions include indicators of the population sex ratio, the sex ratio at birth, mortality rates, and the percentages of births and deaths recorded in the civil registration system. The latest factsheet also lacks indicators on access to sanitation facilities, such as toilets, and to clean cooking fuels. Several indicators for women's health were also removed, such as adolescent fertility rate, type of contraceptives being used, whether health workers had counselled women on family planning, and whether they were informed about the side effects of their chosen contraceptive method.

The factsheet also removed an indicator of women's access to healthcare services — the out-of-pocket expenditure for each delivery. Data on the reach of several health programmes were

also removed, including data on children with diarrhoea who received ORS or zinc, HIV awareness and service delivery, and the waist-to-hip ratio, an indicator of abdominal obesity linked to increased risk of diseases such as diabetes and hypertension.

The data points on screening for the three most common types of cancers — cervical, breast, and oral — were also removed. More than 1.5 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandirs or primary health centres have been upgraded since 2018 to provide screening and care for non-communicable diseases, including the three cancers. However, the uptake of cancer screening services has been poor. NFHS-5 data showed that only 0.9% of people were screened for breast and oral cancers, and 1.9% for cervical cancer.

A Health Ministry source reasoned: "There were several parameters in the NFHS that were being reported by other surveys independently. So, these were removed from the NFHS factsheets in an attempt at data harmonisation between reports produced by the government."

Sources said several of these data points would be provided in other surveys. "Data on cooking fuel is provided in the report on the Ujjwala scheme, and data on sanitation services in the report on Swachh Bharat. When it comes to metrics such as in-

fant mortality, maternal mortality, registration of births and deaths — these are already provided in the Sample Registration Survey. In fact, the total fertility rate (the number of children women have in their lifetime), which is present in this data, is also present in the SRS report," a Health Ministry source said.

The source said data on cancer screening would also be provided by other surveys. The Indian Council of Medical Research usually provides data on cancer prevalence.

The Health Ministry had already announced that indicators about the prevalence and extent of anaemia, which were part of NFHS-5, would not be included in NFHS-6. This was dropped after experts said the current way of measuring it for the survey, using a drop of blood from a finger prick, could overestimate prevalence. A better way, the experts said, was to use venous blood samples. According to sources, data on anaemia using such a method would be reported by the "Diet and Biomarker" survey conducted by the National Institute of Nutrition. NFHS-5 data showed there was an increase in anaemia levels despite the government's 'Anaemia Mukh Bharat' programme that provided iron-folic acid tablets to girls and women to address iron-deficiency anaemia.

RIGHT TO BE FORGOTTEN

Do not index legal records online using names, rules Delhi High Court

Ability to seek erasure ensures informational self-determination remains effective, says court

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 1

EMPHASISING THAT a person being “involuntarily and perpetually” marked in the digital domain violates the right to informational privacy, the Delhi High Court has issued guidelines to search engine operators, such as Google, and legal database platforms to de-index name-based search functionality with respect to judgments, orders or news articles.

The guidelines were laid out in a 144-page verdict delivered on Friday, and made public on Sunday, by Justice Sachin Datta who was hearing a batch of over 38 petitions by individuals seeking removal of digital content involving them.

“The protection under right to informational privacy under

Article 21 (of the Constitution) is not merely against the disclosure of personal information but against an individual being involuntarily and perpetually defined in the digital domain, by such projection, and that too, regardless of the outcome of the underlying legal and judicial proceedings pertaining to such conduct,” the court ruled.

While the court denied relief to public figures and individuals convicted of serious crimes, it upheld the right to be forgotten for individuals in matrimonial and private civil disputes, victims of sexual offences and those acquitted or discharged of crimes. As part of the relief, court records will be “de-indexed” and personal identifiers in such orders will be “masked” protecting their identity.

“No legitimate aim of suffi-

cient specificity is served by the unlimited and unrestricted name-based searchability of records whose underlying proceedings have been resolved, in favour of the concerned individual. Moreover, permanent and unlimited name-based digital searchability, is wholly disproportionate to any legitimate aim that might be identified,” the court said.

De-indexing does not remove or delete a court judgment from public records. It prevents a person’s name from appearing as a search result, making the judgment harder to find through a name-based internet search while keeping it accessible through case details or citations.

“No law authorises Google or any search engine to perpetually index and surface judicial records in a manner that overrides the individual’s fundamental right to informational privacy,” the High Court ruled.

Directing compliance with the direction within two weeks, the court directed legal database

platform Indian Kanoon to restrict name-based search functionality within its platform with respect to records of petitioners who were before the High Court, while making it clear that the “judgments and orders shall remain accessible on Indian Kanoon by case number, citation, Court details and date”.

Justice Datta observed that the right to be forgotten reflects the evolution of privacy in response to the permanence of online information. “... In a society where digital records are virtually indelible, the ability to seek erasure ensures that informational self-determination remains effective. It protects individuals from perpetual exposure to past events that may no longer bear relevance, while preserving their dignity and autonomy in society,” the court observed.

In the absence of a comprehensive statutory framework to govern the right to be forgotten, and while noting that court records are accessible otherwise,

the court held that “a private individual’s name functions as a permanent and unlimited retrieval key through a commercial search engine, enabling any casual internet user to instantly access the entirety of an individual’s engagement with legal/judicial processes...”

The court further said, “... It would be a perverse extension of the concept to hold that open justice facilitates Google (or any other search engine) to thrust an individual’s arrest, accusation or legal misfortune in the face of every person who searches that individual’s name, and to do so with particular force (to ‘satisfy’ a query), without regard to the context. An acquittal buried at the bottom of the ‘search results’, while the arrest dominates the search results, cannot be characterised as an ingredient of ‘open justice.’”

In 2026, the Supreme Court had stayed a similar order of the Delhi HC in which an accused in the Agusta Westland chopper scam case, who was eventually discharged, was granted relief.

DEFENCE MINISTERS' DIALOGUE

India, Australia agree to advance maritime awareness activities

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 1

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh and his Australian counterpart Richard Marles have agreed to advance collaborative maritime domain awareness activities using maritime patrol aircraft and to explore opportunities to enhance undersea domain awareness. The two leaders on Monday co-chaired the second edition of the India-Australia Defence Ministers' Dialogue in New Delhi.

According to a joint statement issued by the two countries, the ministers welcomed the significant progress in bilateral relationship and reflected on the enhanced consultation and cooperation since the inaugural edition of the dialogue on October 9 last year.

The joint statement noted that the two sides discussed efforts to finalise the Joint Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap.

"They agreed to progress the collaborative maritime domain awareness activities by maritime patrol aircraft and explore opportunities to enhance undersea domain awareness," it said, adding that they also encouraged further cooperation between the Indian Coast Guard and Australia's Maritime Border Command.

Marles also met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Monday. After the Meet, Jaishankar posted on X: "A pleasure to meet Deputy Prime Minister & Defence Minister Richard Marles of Australia today. Shared assessments on regional developments, Indo Pacific and further advancement of our Comprehensive Strategic Partnership."



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with Australian Deputy PM and Defence Minister Richard Marles in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

Singh and Marles, during the meet, affirmed the importance of enhancing cooperation with regional partners to help maintain a free, open, peaceful, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific.

"They underscored the importance of freedom of navigation and overflight, and their strong support for unimpeded trade in the region & other lawful uses of the sea consistent with international law, particularly the 1982 United Nations convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)," the statement noted.

The statement further said India and Australia, as co-leads of the Indian Ocean Rim Association Working Group on Maritime Safety and Security, look forward to jointly host a Search & Rescue and tabletop exercise at Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre, Chennai this month to strengthen maritime safety and security cooperation in the Indian Ocean Region.

"The two sides undertook to explore arrangements to enhance procedural interoperability for exercises and operations, building on the 2020 Mutual Logistics Support Arrangement," it said, adding that they also agreed to continue aircraft deployment from each other's territories to build operational familiarity. The ministers announced that India and Australia would begin developing a

E. EXPLAINED

Boost to bilateral ties

India-Australia relations gained significant momentum following PM Narendra Modi's visit to Australia in 2014. The relationship has since produced several key security agreements, including the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and the Mutual Logistics Support Agreement (MLSA).

Memorandum of Understanding regarding the Provision of Defence Articles and Defence Services as the next step in deepening defence industrial collaboration. The two sides agreed to explore further exchanges, including through the Joint Working Group on Defence Industry, Research and Materiel.

The Ministers are keen on exploring future defence science and technology research cooperation in new technology areas like sensor technologies," the statement.

The Australian Deputy Prime Minister invited India to participate in the 2026 Australian Defence Science, Technology and Research Summit.

Both sides also discussed the growing engagement between their defence forces, including in the upcoming Exercise Talisman Sabre 2027, Australia's participation in India's Exercise Milan and Australia's Exercise Kakadu in February and March this year.

"They looked forward to their countries' participation in each other's multinational air exercises in 2026, including operationalising the bilateral Implementing Arrangement on Air-to-Air Refuelling at Exercise Pitch Black," the statement said. It added that the two sides noted with satisfaction the expansion of military cooperation into new areas.

"They welcomed the evolution of Army Exercise Austrialand this year to focus on amphibious combat and littoral manoeuvres. Australia welcomed India's inaugural participation in Operation Render Safe 2026," the statement said, adding that India welcomed Australia's invitation for participation in submarine rescue exercise Black Carillon.

The Ministers welcomed increased information sharing between operational headquarters and said they are looking forward to the inaugural Joint Staff Talks later this year, the statement said. The two leaders encouraged their officials to finalise arrangements for the deployment of an Indian visiting instructor at the Australian Defence College in 2028-2029 to strengthen professional military engagement, knowledge exchange, and strategic alignment.

• ECONOMICS

‘Cheap’ global money flow into India drying up



HARISH DAMODARAN

THE RESERVE Bank of India’s annual report for 2025-26 has expressed concern over “elevated” sovereign bond yields and possible “reversal” of monetary easing (read interest rate hikes) by global central banks, in response to the West Asia crisis-induced inflationary pressures.

That concern has also been articulated by the government’s chief economic advisor V Anantha Nageswaran. In a recent opinion piece for *The Indian Express*, he has pointed to the “end of the era of quantitative easing and near-zero interest rates”, while calling it “perhaps the single most consequential development in global capital markets” in recent times.

To understand what is being said, one must look at yields on 10-year government bonds. A government bond is basically a debt instrument issued by a sovereign authority to borrow money for a specific, predetermined period. In return, the issuer promises to pay a fixed annual interest over the life of the bond and also return the original borrowed amount on its maturity date.

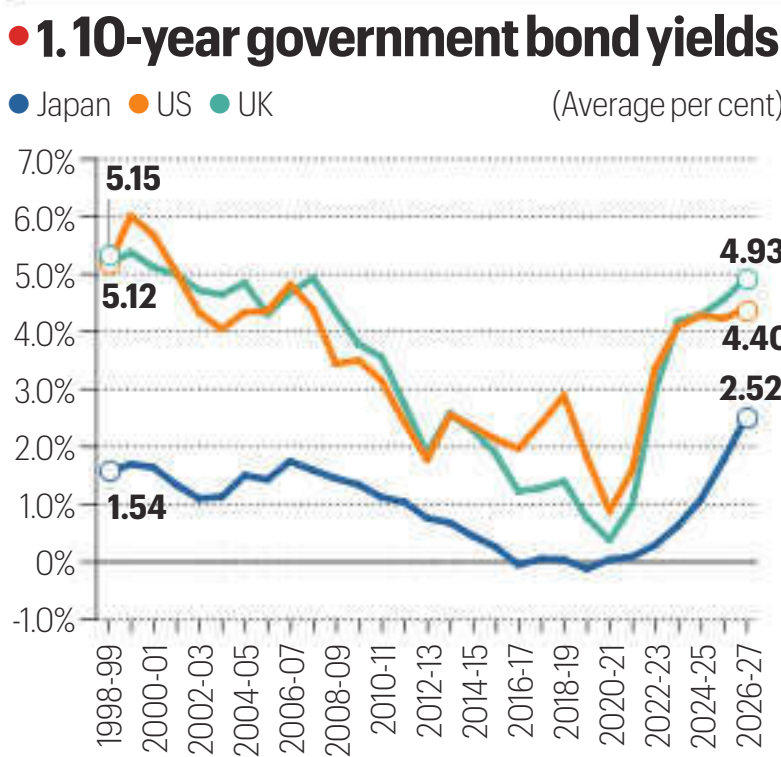
Government bonds are considered to be the safest or close to “risk-free” assets, as their payments are backed by the sovereign’s power to tax or even print money. Government bond yields, in turn, serve as a benchmark for setting interest rates across other fixed-income securities — by establishing the “minimum” return investors would expect for their money over a comparable period.

How yields have moved

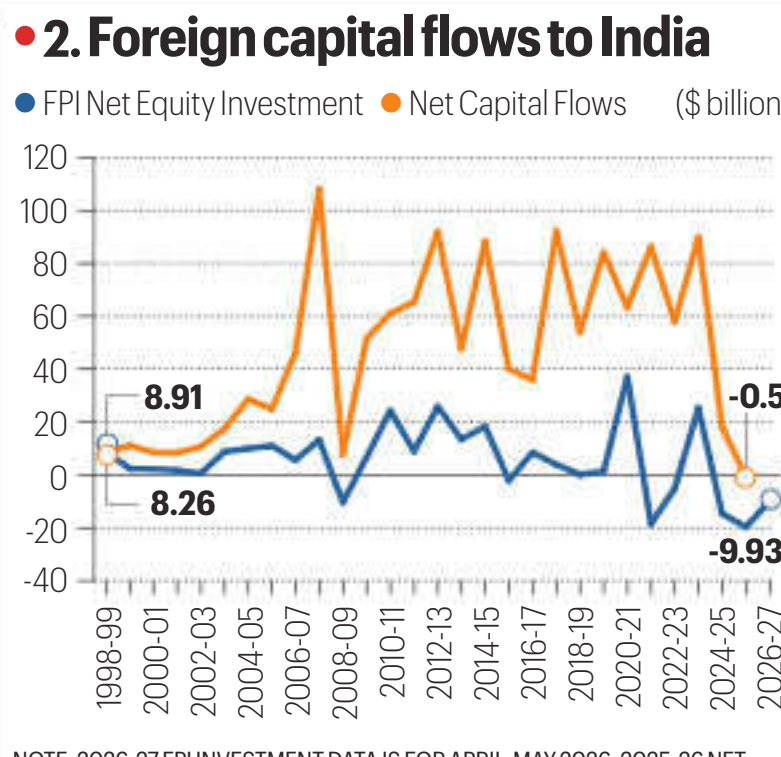
Chart 1 shows the yields or effective annual interest on 10-year government bonds of three major economies — the United States, the United Kingdom, and Japan — since 1998-99.

In 1999-2000 (April-March fiscal year), these averaged over 6% for the US, 5.4% for the UK and 1.7% for Japan. The yields remained relatively high for Japan till 2006-07, averaging 1.75% and almost 2% in April 2006.

From those highs, bond yields steadily



NOTE: 2026-27 DATA IS THE AVERAGE YIELD FOR APRIL-MAY 2026. SOURCE: FEDERAL RESERVE BANK OF ST. LOUIS.



NOTE: 2026-27 FPI INVESTMENT DATA IS FOR APRIL-MAY 2026; 2025-26 NET CAPITAL FLOWS ARE FOR APRIL-DECEMBER 2025. SOURCE: NATIONAL SECURITIES DEPOSITORY LTD AND RESERVE BANK OF INDIA.

‘Risk-free’ assets

Government bonds are considered to be the safest or close to “risk-free” assets, as their payments are backed by the sovereign’s power to tax or even print money.

• Their yields, in turn, serve as a benchmark for setting interest rates across other fixed-income securities.

flation, with supply chain disruptions from the pandemic (2020 and 2021), followed by Russia’s invasion of Ukraine (2022), US President Donald Trump’s unilateral tariff actions (2025) and, now, the unresolved US-Israel versus Iran conflict.

This is reflected in year-on-year consumer price inflation for Japan moving from negative territory to positive in September 2021, reaching 4.3% in January 2023 and hovering at 2-4% thereafter till December 2025. Even the latest 1.4% rate for April 2026 is high by its standards for most of the 1990s, 2000s, and 2010s.

It’s worse for the UK, which registered 9-11% annual inflation from April 2022 to March 2023, and the April 2026 rate at 2.8%. The 3.8% inflation rate in April for the US was the highest since May 2023.

The current inflation levels — and the prospect of their rising further on the back of the higher fuel, fertiliser, and food prices from the West Asia supply shock — have made the ultra-low interest rates and bond yields prevailing till around 2020-21 unsustainable.

The second is the end of the so-called quantitative easing policies of central banks such as the US Federal Reserve to boost economic activity. They resorted to this measure of creating new money for purchasing government bonds and other long-term assets (like mortgage-backed securities) from commercial banks, es-

India was a beneficiary of ultra-low interest rates and quantitative easing by major global central banks. That era is over now

pecially post the 2008 global financial crisis and the pandemic. The objective was to flood the financial system with liquidity, lower long-term rates, and encourage banks to lend more to businesses and consumers.

That regime was also difficult to sustain, given the potential inflationary consequences from the supply of the newly created money increasing faster than the physical production of goods and services. Also, by making government debt cheaper than the interest rates that the markets would otherwise have demanded, it encouraged more borrowing. In the process, governments tended to take on too much debt relative to their capacity to pay back.

The effects of both — high inflation and public debts — are being seen today in the form of elevated sovereign bond yields.

Why this matters for India

When global money was cheap, India was a beneficiary of capital flooding emerging markets in search of higher yields.

Net capital flows into India surged from \$8.3 billion in 1998-99 to a record \$107.9 billion in 2007-08. It collapsed to \$7.8 billion in the 2008-09 financial crisis year, but averaged \$67.3 billion annually between 2009-10 and 2023-24. The tide turned in 2024-25, with net inflows of just \$18 billion. The first nine months of 2025-26 saw net capital outflows of \$580 million.

The trend is even clearer for inflows from foreign portfolio investors (FPI) into Indian equity markets. From 1998-99 to 2020-21, there were only two years of net negative inflows: 2008-09 and 2015-16. Since 2020-21, five out of the six years have witnessed FPIs pulling out more than putting in money (*Chart 2*).

Currently, 10-year government bond yields in India are at about 7%. With US 10-year Treasury note yields at 4.5%, the differential of 2.5 percentage points has significantly narrowed from the historical decade average of 4-plus percentage points. The yield gap is even less if one factors in rupee depreciation and the greater “safe-haven” value from holding US Treasuries.

Foreign capital may still return to India. But it would probably require India offering a more compelling “pull” story (higher GDP and earnings growth prospects) than a “push” from cheap global money that is now history.

• ENVIRONMENT

Gir lion deaths not alarming but flag need for multiple populations



EXPERT EXPLAINS

YADVENDRADEV V. JHALA

SENIOR SCIENTIST, INDIAN NATIONAL SCIENCE ACADEMY, TIFR - NATIONAL CENTRE FOR BIOLOGICAL SCIENCES, BENGALURU

IN GUJARAT’S Gir region, eight lions, including cubs, have died due to a suspected Babesiosis infection caused by the *Babesia* parasite, the state’s Forest and Environment Minister Arjun Modhwadia said Friday. The state Forest Department has isolated lions residing within a 10-km radius of affected areas in Gir Somnath and Amreli districts as a preventive measure, while lions suspected to be affected were being treated, Modhwadia added.

Yadvendra Dev V. Jhala, who is one of India’s foremost wildlife scientists with experience in research on lions and tigers,

spoke to **Nikhil Ghanekar** about how this infection is transmitted and how it impacts lions.

How does Babesiosis get transmitted to lions? What are the symptoms and when does it cause fatality in lions?

Babesia (the parasite) is endemic and prevalent in low levels in livestock, wild ungulates (refers to large mammals with hooves), and even in lions, without causing mortality and without causing symptoms in most cases. Babesiosis is a tick-borne parasitic infection that lions and other wildlife can get from the bite of ticks infected with the *Babesia* parasite.

In nature, there is a host-parasite equilibrium, so that both co-exist, and this rarely needs an intervention. Domestic livestock along with wild ungulates such as chital, nilgai act as asymptomatic reservoirs of *Babesia*. Under nutritional, physiological stress or with other infections, it (*Babesiosis*) can cause mortality.

Babesia acts much like malaria. It is a protozoan, like Plasmodium, and it infects and ruptures red blood cells. The symptoms include lethargy, anaemia, enlarged spleen, and high fever. In conditions of

Protected areas

• The only exclusive space for Asiatic lions is a 250 sq km national park in Gir.

• In contrast, there are 58 tiger reserves within India, each having a human-free space of 800-1,000 sq km.

stress, co-infections, or genetic predisposition, the infection can cause organ failures and mortality.

What is the emergency response in case of suspected Babesia-linked deaths? Do they need intervention?

Natural processes are best left unmanaged in wild populations. As mentioned, wild animals are also reservoirs of several pathogens including *Babesia*. In nature, disease and hosts reach an equilibrium so that both coexist and rarely do need intervention.

There is no need to treat wildlife, and there is no emergency in addressing a few deaths when we have a population of about 1,000 lions. In the case of lions, it would be always nice to spread the risk of epidemics like rabies, canine distemper that can cause catastrophic mortality. This can be done by having multiple un-connected populations (which would act as safety-net populations).

When have such episodes occurred in the past and which has been the most serious one, in terms of mortality?

The epidemic in the lions of Serengeti (Africa) in the mid-1990s is a vivid example of mass mortality wherein almost one-

third of the lion population died within three months. Asiatic lions cannot sustain such an epidemic, and an event like that would risk extinction.

Asiatic lions are also genetically compromised due to a severe historical bottleneck (low genetic diversity) and therefore can easily succumb to disease outbreaks. This is all the more reason to establish several safety-net populations.

Is this a wake-up call to translocate lions to another territory outside Gujarat to safeguard conservation?

The only exclusive space for Asiatic lions is a 250 sq km national park in Gir. In all other parts of its range in Saurashtra including the Gir protected area, they share space with people and livestock and live off human subsidies.

In contrast, tigers occur in 11 countries and have 58 tiger reserves within India, each having a human-free space of 800-1,000 sq km. Conservation biology principles dictate that multiple populations have a much lower risk of extinction compared to any single population. Asiatic lions should be re-established as multiple populations across their historic range.

• HEALTH

Codeine crisis: In dry Bihar, why cough syrup addiction is rising

Himanshu Harsh

Patna, June 1

AS MANY as 7,500 bottles of codeine-based cough syrup were seized in Patna last week by the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI).

As Bihar approaches a decade of alcohol prohibition, codeine cough syrups have surged as a cheap substitute, with seizures and addiction cases rising, especially among youngsters and in rural areas.

What is codeine?

Codeine is a naturally occurring opioid derived from morphine, a compound found in the opium poppy. Used primarily as a cough suppressant, it is found in various medicines, particularly cough syrups, where it works by suppressing the brain’s cough centre.

It is commonly prescribed for upper respiratory infections or chronic conditions like bronchitis, which cause persistent dry coughs. It is not the first-line treatment for common cold.

In therapeutic doses, codeine helps manage severe, persistent coughs that don’t respond to common treatments like antihistamines. The recommended dosage for adults is typically from 10-20 mg every 4-6 hours, up to a maximum of 120 mg daily. Children under the age of 12 are generally advised to avoid it.

Even within the prescribed limits, codeine can cause side effects including drowsiness, constipation, nausea, and dizziness. Misuse can lead to respiratory depression — where breathing becomes dangerously slow — as well as tolerance, addiction, and withdrawal symptoms such as anxiety, sweating, and irritability.

Codeine can also be intoxicating, especially when combined with depressants like alcohol. Overuse can damage the

liver, kidneys, and mental health, leading to psychiatric disorders. Hospitals in Bihar are reporting more young people suffering these long-term effects.

Why codeine?

Codeine syrups are attractive as an alcohol substitute due to their affordability and powerful sedative effects. Their easy availability has contributed to this.

• LIMITED ACCESS

• Critics warn that restricting access to codeine syrups could limit access for legitimate patients suffering from severe coughs.

• This could create a dilemma between public health and individual patient needs.

Despite stringent laws and penalties, including life sentences for alcohol-related offences, the black market for codeine syrup thrives. Recent raids by the Anti-Narcotics Task Force uncovered large illicit stocks, including syrup worth crores of rupees stored in Patna godowns, often controlled by interstate trafficking networks.

In response to the rising misuse, Bihar tightened the regulation of codeine syrups by designating them as “intoxicants” under the Bihar Prohibition and Excise Act in 2016. This restricts sale and possession without a permit, with penalties including fines, confiscation of goods, and imprisonment.

Despite these measures, enforcement remains difficult. Authorities are considering stricter measures, including a total ban on codeine syrups, mandatory e-prescriptions, and more rigorous pharmacy audits. However, experts argue that addressing the root causes of substance abuse like unemployment, poverty, and lack of education could go a long way toward mitigating the issue in the long term.

• GLOBAL

The overlooked conflict: Civil war and humanitarian disaster in South Sudan

Yashee

New Delhi, June 1

AMONG THE United Nations Peacekeepers to be honoured with the Dag Hammarskjöld Medal this year, given to those who lost their lives on UN peacekeeping missions, is Indian national Naib Subedar Sujit Kumar Pradhan, killed in South Sudan last year.

India is the second-largest troops contributor to United Nations Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS), with 4,268 personnel as of March 31. Only Nepal has sent more.

South Sudan is the youngest country in the world, created only 15 years ago. The nation’s short history is marked with such conflict that today, more than half its population faces acute food shortage. The latest round of fighting has been raging since March last year, in which hundreds are estimated dead while thousands have been displaced, though exact figures are hard to come by.

The humanitarian organisation Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF), also called Doctors Without Borders, has been operating in South Sudan almost since the country’s inception. Its Head of Mission, Yashovardhan, told *The Indian Express*, “I was in South Sudan in 2014, in Unity State, when the civil war first broke out in December 2013. Hundreds of thousands of people were displaced and put up in the UN peacekeeping mission compound. This time, I went to Jonglei. After 12 years and in two regions, the situation is the same. People live under the sun with the bare minimum, surviving on wild leaves, berries, and fish. In fact, the UN runs one of its largest food programmes in South Sudan, a country of 12 million people [around the population of Chennai]. People mainly rely on food drops to survive.”

Born of a violent struggle

South Sudan was created after a long struggle for independence from the Republic of Sudan, itself created in 1956 after British and Egyptian colonial rule ended. The



UN staff assist refugees at the Doro camp in South Sudan. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

southern region of this nation felt sidelined and unfairly treated, leading to the birth of South Sudan in 2011.

Two leaders of the independence struggle, the Sudan People’s Liberation Movement, were Salva Kiir, the current

President of South Sudan, and Riek Machar, who served as his Vice President when the country gained independence. Kiir accused Machar of plotting to overthrow him, and the leadership tussle between them flared up into a civil war in 2013, fuelled by local-level tensions and grievances.

Kiir belongs to the Dinka community, while Machar is from the Nuer group. Their supporters rallied behind them, and the two sides fought brutally.

The latest escalation

After five years of fighting, a peace agreement, ‘Revitalised Agreement on the Resolution of the Conflict in the Republic of South Sudan’, was signed in 2018. Machar came back as Vice President.

However, many clauses of the agreement, including holding an election, disarming various groups, and punishing those responsible for grave crimes during the war, were never implemented. Tensions between Machar and Kiir continued

to simmer.

Then in March 2025, the White Army, a militia that supports Machar, had a skirmish with the Army. Within weeks, Machar was placed under house arrest and over the next few months, charged with various crimes, including murder and treason. Fighting has been raging ever since.

Both sides have attacked civilians, and destroyed homes, schools, and civic and medical infrastructure.

Yashovardhan said there have been targeted attacks on medical facilities. “One of our facilities, in Lankien, was bombed. Our medical stores were looted and burnt. The air conditioners were torn down. Essentially, it was left in a shape where it could not be restarted. This was the only facility providing secondary care to 250,000 in Lankien and Jonglei states.”

Humanitarian crisis

A UN report from April says, “Hunger is pushing 56 per cent of South Sudan’s population into high levels of acute food inse-

curity between April and July 2026... Through July this year, 700,000 children are projected to face severe acute malnutrition, the deadliest form.”

The UN mission

UNMISS was set up on July 8, 2011, under Security Council Resolution 1996.

According to the mission’s website, “UNMISS’ most recent mandate, under Resolution 2820 (2026), requires the mission to protect civilians, create the conditions conducive to the safe, timely and unimpeded delivery of humanitarian assistance, use targeted good offices to support the peace process and prevent escalation of political violence, and monitor and report on human rights and international humanitarian law violations and abuses.”

This was the mission Naib Subedar Sujit Kumar Pradhan was deployed with. Another Indian, Lance Havildar Harbhajan Singh, who died last year serving in Congo, is also being honoured with the Dag Hammarskjöld Medal.

The Editorial Page

TUESDAY, JUNE 2, 2026

Health survey calls for a nutrition rethink

FOR CLOSE to two decades, a pattern has been evident in the health profile of Indians. The government's interventions have succeeded, to some extent, in reducing the toll of several communicable diseases. However, lifestyle-related diseases impair the quality of life of a large section of the population. The National Family Health Survey VI, released late last week, flags the alarming proportions taken by diabetes in the country — one in six Indians reported high sugar levels. The challenges posed by the disease are complicated by the increasing obesity rate. Close to 30 per cent of Indians are obese according to the Survey. The two conditions combine to create a vicious metabolic cycle, increasing the risk of hypertension, cardiovascular diseases, kidney and pancreatic disorders, even cancers.

Many developing countries have experienced a similar epidemiological shift as incomes rose, urbanisation accelerated, and lifestyles changed. But India's problem is complicated by the fact that the older challenge of malnutrition has not been completely addressed. The Survey shows that the country is undergoing a double-disease burden. Government initiatives have led to substantial improvement in child nutrition. However, more than 31 per cent of children are still underweight. NFHS VI reveals that more than 80 per cent of infants, between six and 23 months, do not receive an adequate diet. At the same time, childhood obesity is a growing trend in the country.

Several Asian economies adopted a sequential approach — addressing undernutrition first, and then managing metabolic diseases. In India, however, a combination of government policies and people's choices has led to a prioritisation of calorie intake at the cost of nutritional diversity. Diets have shifted towards refined carbohydrates and processed foods. At the same time, children in marginalised communities lack access to diverse diets. The Comprehensive Nutritional Survey, released last year, showed that 35 per cent of children have adult-level triglycerides that predispose them to metabolic and cardiovascular diseases. Government nutrition programmes have tried to provide a corrective. However, these have focused excessively on supply-side interventions without adequately appreciating how the family, especially mothers, influences children's food intake. In the coming months, the NFHS data will become more granular. That should push the government towards fine-tuning policies and programmes to reduce India's disease burden.

New algorithms, same old exploitation of gig workers



AVDHESH KUMAR

FOOD AND grocery delivery platforms claim they are no longer pushing workers to complete deliveries within 10 minutes. Yet the larger question remains unresolved: Can delivery workers truly escape the pressure of time-bound labour in a fiercely competitive platform economy? Whether in product deliveries, ride-hailing services, or customer support systems, digital platforms continue to operate on the logic of speed and constant availability.

This logic is not entirely new. Karl Marx, in his theory of surplus value, and David Harvey in *The Limits to Capital* (1982) and *The Condition of Postmodernity* (1989), explained how capitalism seeks to reduce the time required for the circulation of commodities and capital. Technological advancements have intensified this tendency by enabling faster production, delivery, and labour extraction. The platform economy is an example of this. However, can workers' dignity, identity, social security, and welfare survive within these digitally controlled workplaces?

During my recent fieldwork in Delhi, I interacted extensively with delivery workers employed by food and grocery applications. One phrase repeatedly surfaced: “*Jitna zyada kaam karoge utna kamaoge*” — the more you work, the more you earn. This resembles the old capitalist promise that hard work guarantees better earning, a belief that continues to dominate India's labour market. However, the condition of gig workers reveals a different story. Many delivery agents reported working more than 84 hours a week simply to break what they colloquially call the “incentive tala” (lock) — a threshold that must be crossed before higher incentives become available. Even after such exhausting schedules, most workers in Delhi earn only between Rs 25,000 and Rs 30,000 a month. They must manage fuel expenses, vehicle EMI and maintenance, rent, and family responsibilities from this. Rising fuel prices have deepened their vulnerability, making workers increasingly dependent on uncertain state interventions and inconsistent platform policies.

Equally troubling is the growing role of technology and artificial intelligence in regulating labour. Gig work is often presented as technologically neutral, but workers frequently suspect that human managers continue to intervene through algorithmic systems. They have little clarity regarding how incentives are altered, how performance metrics are determined, or why penalties suddenly appear. Dynamic targets and changing incentive structures continuously pressure workers to do more to earn more.

Although the government has recently proposed reforms through the four labour codes and introduced welfare-related recommendations for gig workers, awareness remains limited. One significant proposal was the introduction of formal job-offer letters to provide legitimacy to gig workers. Yet most delivery workers remain unaware of these developments.

Historically, systems such as Taylorism and Fordism justified labour exploitation in the name of efficiency and precision. Today, app-based algorithms appear to reproduce similar forms of control through digital surveillance and psychological manipulation. The challenge is clear: Can workers be protected from these new forms of exploitation within the expanding platform economy?

The writer is assistant professor, Lal Bahadur Shastri Institute of Management, Delhi

Many delivery agents reported working more than 84 hours a week simply to break what they colloquially call the ‘incentive tala’ (lock) — a threshold that must be crossed before higher incentives become available

The Ideas Page

TUESDAY, JUNE 2, 2026

India needs more schools, medical colleges, entrepreneurship in education



MANISH SABHARWAL

SCOTT ANDERSON'S excellent book *King of Kings* documents the Shah of Iran's curt reaction to food shortage warnings in 1978 as "There are no shortages, only hoarding by greedy businessmen." The technocratic reply that "hoarding depended on shortages" angered the emperor, who then ordered people to "stop complaining and work harder". This royal delusion — the Shah was unemployed within 12 months — echoes the regulatory cholesterol holding back a massive entrepreneurial response to India's voracious demand for education. While tactical responses are necessary before 21 lakh-plus students retake the NEET-UG exam on June 21, the only lasting solution is to expand supply through deregulation that empowers education technocrats, such as principals and deans, to set up institutions.

India's inability to create mass prosperity arises from the low productivity of our employers and youth. Reforms over the past decade have focused on employer productivity; we must now tackle outdated regulations choking the expansion of schools, colleges, and universities. The Radhakrishnan Commission of 1948 and the Kothari Committee of 1968 responded to educator John Gardner's challenge to design education systems that are equal and excellent. But India's youth population today is larger than America's total population. We are no longer a poor, new, and hesitant republic, and our education policy should stop behaving like one. This entails ending five false binaries.

Quantity vs Quality: India has run a randomised control trial in education regulation. The Medical Council of India was bribed to keep medical capacity down, while the All India Council for Technical Education was bribed to expand engineering capacity. This means we have 16 lakh engineering seats every year, but only 1.3 lakh MBBS seats. Capitation fees have largely disappeared in engineering but ex-

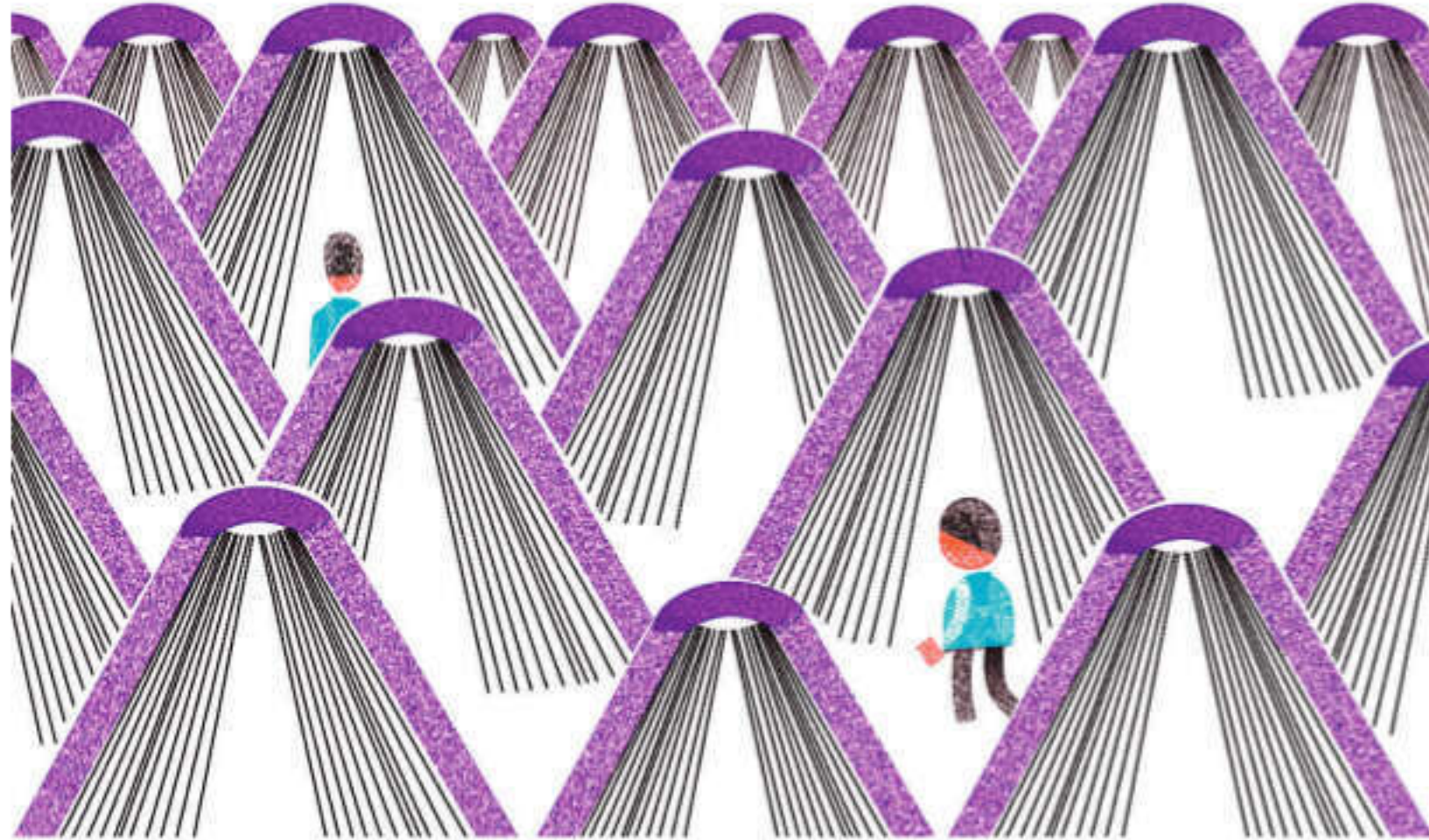


ILLUSTRATION: C.R. SASIKUMAR

ploded in medicine. Unlike Athena, who sprang fully formed from the head of Zeus in Greek mythology, educational institutions are not born adults. Over time, the goofy engineering colleges set up in the 1980s in Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu have improved, providing the supply chain for India's software industry. Nearly 30 per cent of engineering seats now lie vacant. Weak colleges are closing, and good colleges are raising faculty salaries.

Public vs Private: The debates over public vs private, or foreign vs domestic, institutions are juvenile. We should only care about good vs bad schools. But India's education regulations are obsessed with hardware over software, legal structures over learning, and input metrics over outcomes. This creates adverse selection among education entrepreneurs because success requires lying at birth (not unlike legislators' election-spending affidavits) and lifelong regulatory "management" skills (creating a gap between how the law is written, interpreted, practised, and enforced).

Repair vs Prepare: Few disagree with Mark Twain's quip that education is not the filling of a bucket but the lighting of a fire. But ad-

ressing poverty needs learning for earning as much as learning for living. This does not mean India must vocationalise school education or imitate Singapore by streaming children too early, but it does mean recognising that what we can teach someone in six months (a plumber, mason, salesperson or customer service worker) takes 15 years to learn (confidence, curiosity, creativity or communication skills). The most important vocational skills are the old four Rs: Reading, writing, arithmetic and relationships, and too many government schools (50 per cent of enrolment) fail at these basics. Why are half of our kids paying for something to avoid something free? Because a 21st-century education makes the strange familiar through knowledge, but also the familiar strange through questioning.

Price vs Cost: The challenge for great educational institutions is reconciling high costs for faculty and infrastructure, but low fees for diversity and inclusion. Predictably, debates around fair fees and reasonable profits provoke outrage. But India already knows price controls don't work; private schools simply invent 20 different fee categories. The most expensive

Coaching factories, exam leaks, nursery-school interviews and unemployability mean an Indian child's most important decisions are choosing their parents and pin code wisely

school is no school at all.

Excellence vs Inclusion: India's inequality of opportunity means our most valued institutions inhabit two extremes — either the IITs and IIMs, with narrow entry gates (99 per cent fail) and wide-open exits that require elimination rather than selection entry exams, or the chartered accountant qualification with wide entry gates and narrow exits (99 per cent fail). But weak competition for most schools means their wide-open entry and exit gates lead to poor learning outcomes, weak signalling value and rotten employability.

The solution is clear: More education entrepreneurship through deregulation. Removing the state government NOC requirement for Central Board recognition — state registration is already mandatory under the Right to Education Act. Deleting the RTE clause that prescribes jail for schools that conduct admission evaluations — should we select IIT or IIM students by lottery? Allowing all companies, not just Section 8 ones, to open schools and colleges so that education technocrats can become entrepreneurs by legally raising external capital. Scrapping minimum land requirements that confuse building schools with school buildings ensures that most education entrepreneurs are politicians, crooks, and landowners. Regulations that reward legal shenanigans or regulatory "management" handicap talent without capital and capital without talent.

My job in a people supply chain company involved hiring someone every five minutes for 25 years. But only hiring 5 per cent of applicants converted me to Amartya Sen's idea of development as freedom. An uneducated Indian is not a free Indian. Coaching factories, exam leaks, nursery-school interviews and unemployability mean an Indian child's most important decisions are choosing their parents and pin code wisely. The solution is not licensing but supply. Competition will drive innovation in teaching, fees, productivity, multilingual instruction, gifted students, teacher training and employability. India doesn't need fewer cooks in the kitchen; it needs more cooks, more recipes and fewer bureaucrats guarding empty plates.

The writer is co-founder of Teamlease Services and co-author of Made in India



PETER KYLE

In volatile world, UK-India ties can be a game changer

STRONG PARTNERSHIPS are more important than ever. The global economy is being buffeted by shocks on all sides and businesses are being forced to grapple with ever greater complexity and volatility. At times like this, it is hard to overstate the value of providing certainty, stability, and long-term opportunity with trusted trading partners.

These are the values embedded in the relationship between India and the UK. Less than a year ago, Prime Ministers Narendra Modi and Keir Starmer set a new course for our relationship — the UK-India Vision 2035, which set the direction for the next 10 years.

This plan covers everything from growth and jobs to education, technology, climate, and defence. Throughout every aspect is woven the same clear message — we are both better for working together. I have the privilege of delivering part of that vision alongside my friend and counterpart, Minister Piyush Goyal. It is our responsibility to work closely, both with business and with each other, to help turbo-charge our trading relationship and unlock new opportunities — driving growth and creating jobs.

In many respects, our relationship is already delivering on this ambition. In 2025, trade between the UK and India was £48bn — almost double in current prices what it was in 2019. And I am confident that we will only see this trend continue when we bring the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement, or CETA, into force.

In today's world, growth will be driven not just by the movement of goods, but by ideas, data, and technology. This is where the UK-India partnership is especially powerful

Our deal is a genuine game changer. It will be the most expansive deal that India has ever brought in and the most economically significant deal the UK has done since leaving the European Union — and could increase India's and the UK's GDP by an estimated £5.1 billion and £4.8 billion respectively. This deal means real opportunities for real businesses. Some 99 per cent of UK and 90 per cent of Indian tariffs will be slashed, saving exporters and importers alike hundreds of millions of pounds.

New processes will make trade quicker, cheaper, and easier, including improving the use of digital contracts. Services companies will benefit from locked-in access and new business mobility commitments that will enable specialists from both nations to seamlessly deliver their expertise in everything from financial services, education and information technology to yoga. And in today's world, growth will be driven not just by the movement of goods, but by ideas, data, and technology. This is where the UK-India partnership is especially powerful. Our countries are leaders in digital innovation and our businesses are already collaborating to solve problems that matter: Improving healthcare outcomes, strengthening financial inclusion, and accelerating the transition to net zero.

As a former technology minister, I have seen first-hand how innovation can transform businesses and econ-

omies alike. The next phase of UK-India co-operation will be defined by exactly this spirit: Harnessing emerging technologies to unlock new markets, support high-quality jobs, and build industries of the future. When I speak to businesses across the UK, I hear time and again how excited they are to strengthen their relationship with India — one of the fastest-growing major economies globally, a powerhouse of talent, technology and entrepreneurship.

And when I last visited India with Prime Minister Starmer, I heard from scores of businesses in Mumbai what they see in the UK — the number one country in Europe for attracting venture capital, the fastest cumulative economic growth amongst European G7 economies over 2026 and 2027, and the home to global hubs in finance, services, innovation, research, and international investment. So, as I visit India today, to further progress our trading relationship and prepare for the entry into force of the CETA, I am reminded of a simple but powerful truth: When the UK and India work together, we both benefit — and so does the wider global economy.

As I said to begin, in a world of volatility, certainty is a valuable currency. The UK-India relationship provides that certainty — anchored as two democracies, strengthened by economic complementarity, and driven by a common ambition for growth.

The writer is UK Business and Trade Secretary

NEW IIP SERIES UPGRADES INDUSTRIAL GROWTH RATE FOR LAST THREE YEARS

April industrial growth at 4.9% vs 3.2% in March

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 1

INDIA'S INDUSTRIAL output grew by 4.9% in April, higher than the 3.2% growth recorded in March, according to the new Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data series released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) on Monday.

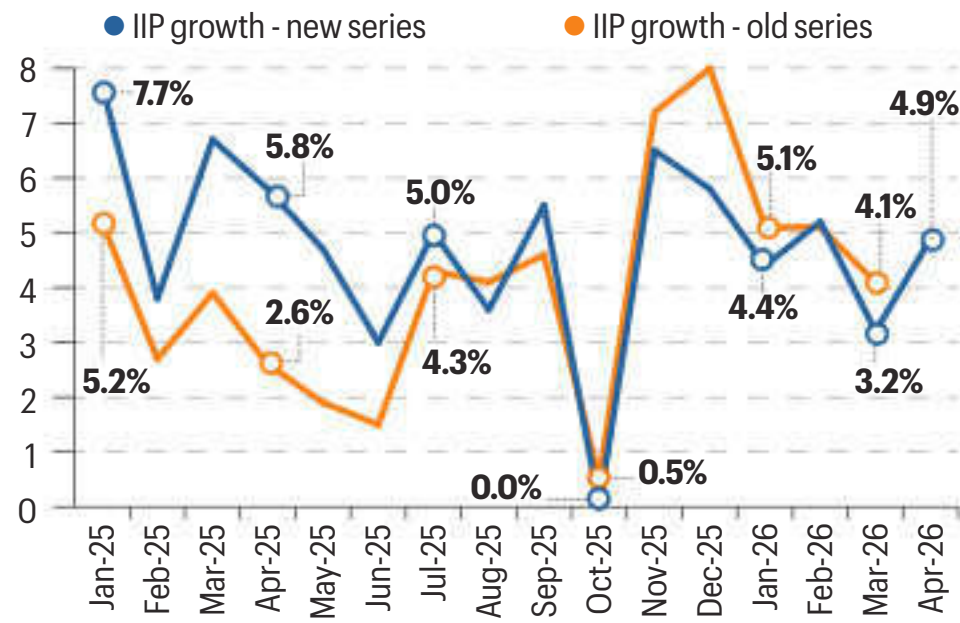
The new IIP series, which has 2022-23 as the base year as against 2011-12 in the old one and updates various methodologies used in the compilation of the index and broadens the coverage of the economic indicator, also upgraded the industrial growth rate for the last three years. IIP growth in 2023-24, 2024-25, and 2025-26 is now estimated at 6.7%, 6.4%, and 4.3%, respectively.

In the old 2011-12 series, the respective industrial growth rates were 5.9%, 4%, and 4.1%.

The higher industrial growth in the past three years as per the new series is primarily due to upward revisions in manufacturing and electricity growth. In April, industrial growth was driven by manufacturing sector, whose output rose 6.2% from same month last year. The manufacturing sector has a 76% weight in the new series, up from 78% in the 2011-12 series.

Meanwhile, output of 'water supply, sewerage & waste management' and 'electricity & gas

● Old vs new IIP series: Industrial growth rate



New series has 2022-23 as base year, old series 2011-12 SOURCE: MoSPI

supply' rose 6.6% and 4.9%, respectively, in April. However, 'mining and quarrying' output contracted 5.1%.

Within electricity and gas supply, MoSPI now provides a break-up of electricity generated through renewable and non-renewable sources. In April, electricity generation from renewable sources was 18% higher compared to only 2.8% growth for electricity from non-renewable sources. But electricity from non-renewable sources has a much higher weight of 7.8% in the IIP compared to 2.3% for renewable sources.

The impact of West Asia war was seen in the supply of gas, which was down 11.2% compared to April 2025.

According to Barclays econ-

omists Aastha Gudwani and Amruta Ghare, the recovery in 'manufacture of chemicals' — whose output rose 0.4% in April following a 4.9% fall in March — "corroborates our view that peak shortages for industrial inputs (from gas and petrochemicals rationing) seen in March saw gradual improvement in supply in April and May". And while the manufacture of coke and refined petroleum products was 0.5% lower in April compared to last year, "the sector growth was generally subdued even prior to the conflict".

"As such, we would not entirely attribute the Middle-East-related disruptions to output weakness here," the economists added.

In terms of use-based classifi-

Centre's April fiscal deficit at 26-month high; FY26 target met

New Delhi: Amid mounting pressures from the West Asia war, the Centre's fiscal deficit surged to a 26-month high of Rs 3.62 lakh crore in the first month of FY27, accounting for 21.4% of the full-year target of Rs 16.96 lakh crore, data showed Monday.

While the fiscal deficit in April was up 94% on year, the revenue deficit nearly quadrupled to Rs 1.82 lakh crore as receipts fell 24% and expenditure rose 23%. Meanwhile, the Centre also said it met the fiscal deficit target of 4.4% of GDP for 2025-26. ENS

cation of goods produced, output of primary goods was 0.8% higher in April, while that of capital goods rose 16% and intermediate goods 77%. Infrastructure goods' production was 7.1% higher. On the consumer front, 4.3% more durable goods were produced in April, while growth in non-durables was 2.8%.

Going forward, economists expect industrial growth to remain subdued due to weaker global demand and supply chain disruptions. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 1

"The Indian market is of strategic importance for FIFA as it displays immense potential driven by a young and passionate audience. We believe the extensive broadcast and digital distribution ecosystem of 'Z' coupled with their deep understanding of local viewers and multi-platform capabilities will play a pivotal role in expanding the reach of football with fans across every part of India," FIFA Chief Business Officer Romy Gai is quoted as saying in the statement.

The 2022 World Cup in Qatar, won by Lionel Messi's Argentina, was reportedly acquired for around Rs 480 crore (\$60 million). Industry estimates suggest broadcasters struggled to recover even half the investment through advertising revenues, making FIFA's initial asking price this time commercially unviable for major players.